

Art and Myth

By PAULZ.ROTTERDAM

ON May 29, 1945, at six o'clock in the morning it was raining in Amsterdam. Two police officers knocked at the door of Hans Van Meegeren, painter, declaring his arrest for high treason against the state. His name had been found in connection with papers showing the sale of Dutch master paintings to the Nazis during the war. Especially the sale to Hermann Goering of a Vermeer painting, designated as a national treasure, put Van Meegeren under suspicion of collaboration with the enemy. After weeks of denial, Van Meegeren confessed to the crime but with the inclusion of a statement which stunned the world even in those hectic post-war times: the painting in question was not a Vermeer but had been painted by Van Meegeren himself. He also admitted to several newly discovered De Hooches and other Vermeers, and the greatest

nightmare of all was his claim to have done the famous "Christ at Emmaus" by Vermeer, which by then had been hanging for seven years in the Boijmans Museum in Rotterdam. When this painting went on the market in 1937, its authenticity certified by the most outstanding Vermeer experts in the world, acclaimed in numerous publications as the ultimate master-work of Vermeer and sold to the museum for the incredible price of 550,000 guilders, it constituted the centerpiece of the 1938 exhibition of 450 Dutch masters. Enormous crowds of visitors were led to a separate room with carpets on the floor in order not to disturb the silence of contemplation and the feeling of mystical serenity which emanated from the work as from an altar, as critics described it. The most popular painting in Holland was said to contain all the elements of the

holy, the mystical, the spiritual which convert the viewing of a painting into a pilgrimage to a sacred shrine through which man's inner state is liberated from the anxieties of the world and healed by a wondrous, purely religious spirit.

Today, forty years after Van Meegeren's painting was de-moted to the museum's corridor, it seems easy to say that the painting represents a false pathos, that the heads are like decorated balls floating over the canvas, that the fingers are painted like dead sausages with fingernails stuck on them, that the hair is wet and hanging down in strands as if it just came out of the rain, that the shadows are arbitrary, the whole arrangement of form dull, etc. And what about the spiritual? Did it suddenly evaporate by the new sun of truth which rose as soon as the clouds of pretense were lifted? Altogether, the example of Van Meegeren reveals an unstable weather condition with a low pressure area surrounding the phenomenological conditions of a painting itself and what we denote as the spiritual forces contained in it.

Cao Fei
Whose Utopia?, 2006
Single-channel video
Video still

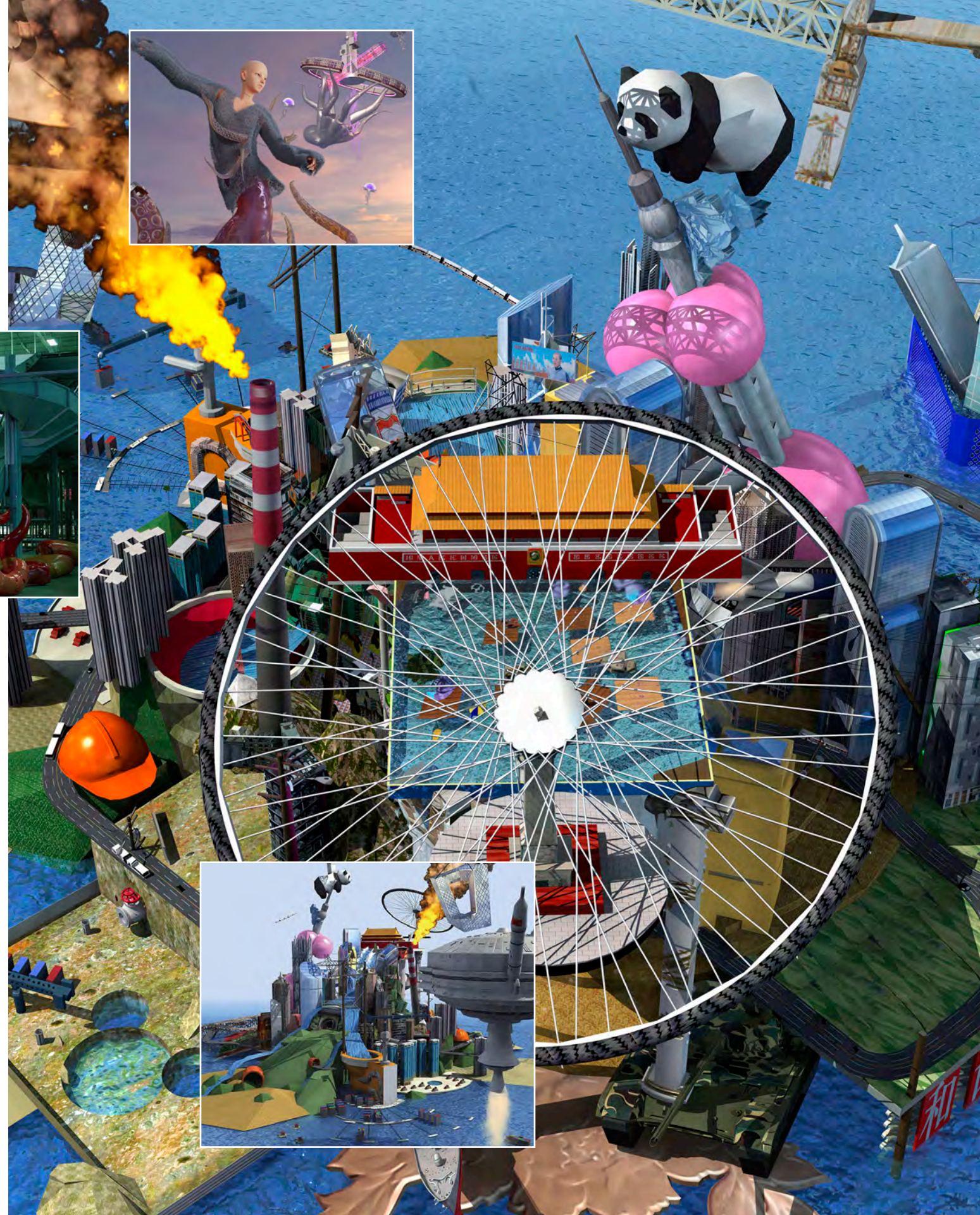
Cao Fei
RMB City: A Second Life City
Planning, 2007-2011
Video
50 minutes 57 seconds



The Spiritual in Art

If the spiritual is one day contained in the phenomenon and the next day has escaped through the introduction of hitherto unknown facts, the spiritual is either not contained in the phenomenon itself or the effect of transcendence is only imagined as a result of expectations of spirituality which in itself however has no a priori position in art. But why would we talk about the spiritual, the mystical, the transcendent if we did not a priori assume that it can precisely be found in art and that certain works contain it more than others? In fact, the whole question of quality centers on the amount and intensity of the spiritual in art. Individual works are criticized in terms of their phenomenological constituents, the formal features which are the source and the effect of a spirituality which rescues the painting from its existence as an empty visual matter. However, since the spiritual may one day be present in the phenomenon and the next day be absent, it can be assumed that the spiritual is not something like a ghost or a vapor flying in front of every painting that contains certain formal features. It must rather be attached to both the painting and the beholder in a mutually inclusive manner. The values sought in a painting presuppose perspectives of evaluation which differentiate and create the corresponding visual values. In this sense, the Van Meegeren painting possessed the spiritual values attractive at the time, namely, a post-nineteenth-century sentimentalism of Realist painting which was mistaken for the heroic and the mystical. Exactly because it resembles nothing that Vermeer had ever done, it was assumed to be the greatest Vermeer ever, since the master was supposed to have made the ultimate push into a style of sentimental pathos that in the 1930s was widely appreciated as official art and connected with the expectations of high art not only by dictatorial regimes but by much of European society.

A work is sometimes this, sometimes that, depending on the forces which take possession of it. The question of essence is therefore concerned with the synthesis of forces which have greatest affinity with what is already in the possession of the object and the forces which struggle for its possession. There is something tragic in this because nothing would suit us better than to know an essence in art which stands unobscured in front of our imagination, a desirable condition for works which can be attained



Cao Fei
RMB City: A Second Life
City Planning, 2007-2011
Video
50 minutes 57 seconds



Cao Fei
Cosplayers Series - Tussle,
2004
C-print
29 1/2 x 39 2/5 in / 75 x
100 cm

Cao Fei
RMB City: A Second Life
City Planning, 2007-2011
Video
50 minutes 57 seconds

concerned with values which assemble them□ serves through a contextual relationship of the phenomenon with the same or similar classes of objects. The creation of paintings for the purpose of appearance or the beautiful alone is an unacceptable enterprise since the effect of beauty is already and perhaps more fully contained in normal reality. A

beauty which makes a value in art reveals a hitherto concealed condition of the world. And, most of all, it unfolds a truth about the human condition, namely, the individual substance of the artist, his attitude toward the world, through the characteristics of his work. We look at paintings only to look at painters. Painting is the art in which a recognition manifests itself as an emotion. We recognize feelings of painters through paintings. Paintings form a class of characteristics which carry the particular attitude of the artist: his style.

as long as we struggle for it hard enough. But if a single work would show us what the essence of art is, then it would be unnecessary to look at other art. The myth of art, which keeps our interest alive, is the trend of general interpretation of reality which manifests itself in the kind of working, the particularity of feeling expressed by individual artists. In that sense, the visual characteristics in a work are not its essence but its possibility of appreciation.

Kant tells us that a loving couple sitting out in nature con-siders itself blessed when in addition to the beauty of the surrounding landscape a nightingale starts to sing. When they find out, however, that the sound of the nightingale had been produced by a mischievous boy hiding in a tree the whole situation is destroyed. One and the same stimulus can produce different strata of appreciation. Once the paintings of Van Meegeren were discovered as products which pretended a history of production requisite to a class of paintings belonging to an earlier century, their value changed. Our moral indignation derives from our knowledge about the displayed characteristics in a painting not being genuinely derived from a historical or subjective necessity but from its recreation of an old master look. It has suddenly shifted into the realm of a conceptual enterprise. All conceptual enterprises in art disturb us in this way. Our awareness of a painting's existence for an intellectual purpose disturbs our willingness to recreate it in terms of an emotional necessity. Masterworks conceal their intellectual propositions by the intensity of a single emotion condensed into the autonomy of the art object itself. Art works are not billboards for the illustration of ideas but objects which lead into their own internal necessity of existence.

Since awareness of the inner truth of an aesthetic object is not guaranteed by its visual appearance, there must be something contained and yet concealed in the object which is the same and yet different from the exhibited characteristics. Aesthetics can therefore not be a branch of psychology which observes how Wittgenstein's dog wags his tail in front of his master or how much pleasure we get in front of our masters, but it must be a branch of philosophy concerned with the value system in the back of your mind when standing in front of a painting. It is one thing to say "This painting is beautiful" and another to make the judgment "This is art." The first is a theoretical judgment based on attributes, while the second is a critical judgment

Style

Style is not something which the artist can decide upon as a goal. It is not a manner in which to work but an emotional necessity expressed through an attitude, a way of visual pre-sentation which remains the same even if the outer appear-ance of the individual works changes. The spiritual is the underlying basis for various phenomena and the unifying principle. Even though there is always a definite intellectual directive for the creation of a certain type of work within historical circumstances, there is no reasoning as to the why of a style; reason always finds its way back to inner necessity. While it is true that certain works could have been created only at a particular time because not everything is possible at all times, I still believe that the elementary emotion expressed remains the same, regardless of the visual particulars in a style. Even though certain formal relationships or techniques are pursued consciously or working strategies are consolidated for the future, the artist is still bound to his own unique energy, which expresses itself in the attitude of his style. Style is an elementary proposition which in itself cannot be further analyzed. The emotion represented by a sequence of works is on a relatively simpler and more condensed level than the individual works. When we think of paintings we hardly think of their particular appearance, but we think of the attitude of the painter. The name of each of our familiar painters is connected with a particular type of feeling. The myth in art is the myth which the artist has created for himself. It doesn't make sense for the artist to work only on his paintings; an artist has to work on himself. Among the many propositions which are available to painting, the painter chooses those which carry his feeling with the greatest intensity. If we put all available propositions into a funnel, the emotions flow fastest in the channel where the propositions are narrowest. A painter who continues his work throughout his life is not adding more work of the same kind into the already existing household of reality; by adding paintings he is subtracting from the possibilities of interpretation. A single example is more complex than a whole proposition, a style. Style, while simpler, is also stronger because it shapes a more precise vision of reality. Simplicity of proposition is synonymous with strength in the visual arts. Value does not derive from the introduction of a multiplicity of separate meanings, as in literature, but power in the visual arts derives from the condensation of the visually presented in one single uninterrupted stream of consciousness which works as

a fine emotion. The visual arts are the only arts in which a recognition manifests itself as an emotion. But this emotion is recognized only in the context with what we have recognized in the past in either normal reality, in art or in the works of the same artist. We cannot get tired of looking at more and more works of the masters because the more clearly their singular energy emerges, the more appetite we have for them. Each new work leads us into the connection with the energy or the attitude which we have appreciated already.

The single Van Meegeren painting was connected with the anticipation and the emotional knowledge aroused from high art and in particular with the emotion intuited or aroused by Vermeers because it pretended to belong to a chain of works which generates such an emotion. The entire painting style of Vermeer and its particular emotion were shifted through the introduction of one foreign painting.

The emotions aroused by a single work of art or by an unknown artist are much more vulnerable to misinterpretation than the emotions aroused by a whole style. Single appearances in the history of art are less defined by family resemblances and therefore easily attach themselves as parasites to visually similar styles. And reversedly, the emotions aroused by strong styles are easily carried over into single, visually similar works. This means that feelings in art do not reside or come from the phenomenon itself but are similar to laundry hanging between poles; the emotional, the spiritual, the transcendent manifests itself contextually in the empty space between works, or—on a preaesthetic level—in the space between created images and reality itself.

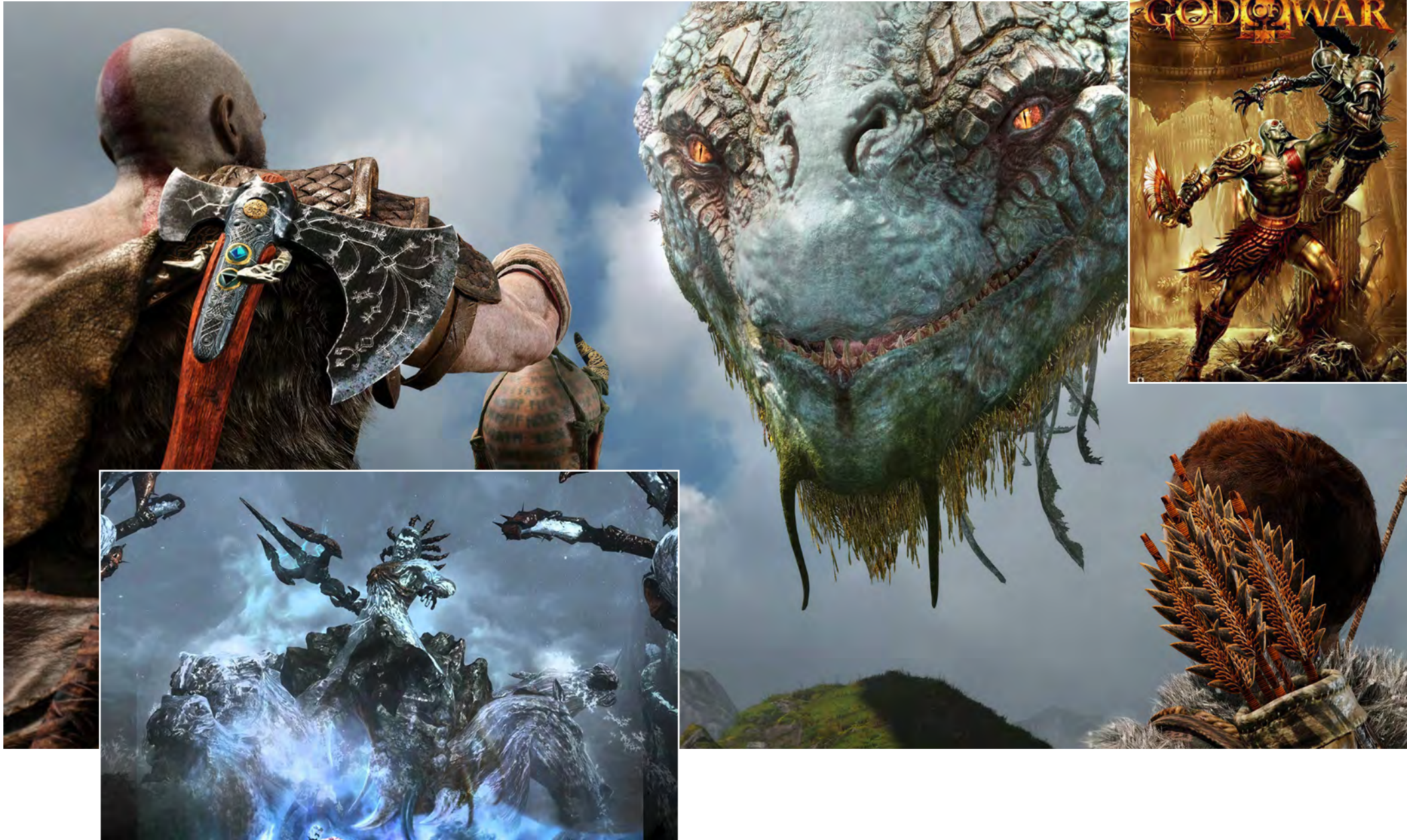
The concept of style, to be sure, cannot be taken as the sole criterion for the definition of art. Even though it is an elementary proposition which cannot be analyzed any further and approximates something like an essence in art, we cannot say that the creation of what is known as family resemblance guarantees the inclusion under the concept of art. A shoemaker who produces a certain type of boot for the market can also be said to have style and yet his product aspires to no more than craft, which takes for granted a certain tradition limited in its freedom for new solutions to old design problems. The pursuit of design problems in art is as futile an enterprise as the pursuit of formal beauty because once certain solutions have been found they

either become stale or are replaced by other problems. Masters resist analytical extrapolation of the elements of their style because what constituted the formal properties of their style in the past is not an overt or guaranteed end for their future. They live out of their energy, which they trust more than past accomplishments, and expose themselves to new challenges and formal risks. Academic painters beat the same forms until they are dead. They certainly succeed in attaching a visual label to their name which identifies their works from a hundred yards because once you have seen one painting you know them all. Their repetition of earlier formal manifestations leads the beholder into the phenomenon of the painting as a formal mechanism instead

of allowing us to transcend the picture in terms of a particular emotion which proves itself in a new visual experience. All masters are easily identifiable also, not because we see the same picture in a different color but because we recognize their feelings through their approach to painting when coming to grips with their imagination. Painting cannot rely on a look. A modernist look addresses itself to the expectations of modernism as Van Meegeren's look addressed itself to the expectations of old master painting. Working for a look is working for the expectations of the world. Expectations imply knowledge. Why should a painter pursue what is generally known already?

David Jaffe
God of War II, 2007
Video game
Gameplay still

Santa Monica Studio
God of War, 2018
Video game
Gameplay still



Uniqueness

The myth in art is the uniqueness of expression which an individual has created for himself apart from all other exam-ples in the history of art. Uniqueness manifests itself in the newness of style because newness means uniqueness of emo-tion. All great names in the history of art have separat-ed themselves on the basis of innovations which opened new avenues for a new state of conscious-ness. All innovations can be appreciated in the con-text of what is older art. The greatest artists have the greatest insights into art because their inno-vations are not superficial reactions to the works of other artists but derive from a careful analysis of the premises on which art as a whole is based. And since the emotions in art operate out of real life, the masters must have had a great insight into life itself, for it is life which contains the inspira-tional emotions condensed in a style which carries a single uninterrupted stream of consciousness. The feelings expressed in his style represent the myth in which he senses the world. He redis-covers this myth in his work, which he substitutes for reality. The entire enterprise of art must have its origin in the longing for transcendence of reality. The creat-ed works shift our con-sciousness onto a level which cannot be obtained from actual life. Works of art affect us emotionally in the context of real life and in the context of emotions had from other art. The more art and life we know, the sharper our senses of appreciation for the differences or similarities of emotions received by the works of different artists. The energy which manifests itself in the work of the masters as a visual attitude does not lie exposed in the work; as a structure it can be understood only in the context of an assimilation of past and pres-ent experience. But no such attitude in works can be experienced by someone who is not in touch with himself or who has never had previous experience with art; he must rather stare in astonishment or bewilderment.

While it is true that there is a contemplation of the thing for its own sake and how pleasantly or un-pleasantly you are af-fected by it, the apprehension of aesthetic value is the com-plete development and consummation of an act of looking for the sake of an experience and the creation of a consciousness which includes all facets of past experience with the world as well as with art. But knowledge of art does not guarantee the recognition of the finest feelings



in it because intellectual and emotional ability are two different strata of consciousness. We are not ready for any master at any time. We are ready to absorb the feeling from a work if that which we absorb is already contained in us. And in order to absorb we need the power of intuition. Intuition orders knowl-edge into a man-ifestation which possesses persua-sion about truth. Art does not contribute to the bas-ket of analytical knowledge but it per-suades you about the truth of a particular feeling. You may un-derstand everything about the formal constituents and the history of art and yet not get the drift of the content you supposedly know because you get it only if you are persuaded. You may be convinced about the value of a particular work and yet may not be persuaded by its emotional truth.

To make this point more tangible I would like to tell a story which I have told before. A few years ago I lived in a tiny village in Texas very close to what they call the hill country desert. After some time I noticed that every day at almost the same hour in

the early evening a very distinctive sound of an animal could be heard; I thought it might be a frog or some other rare animal. The woman in the coun-try store told me that it was the green stone eater, an animal which measures a little more than a foot, is all green, lives two feet under-ground, and eats nothing but stones. Every evening it comes to the surface and makes its sound. The people on the East Coast would not believe this story, the woman said, because they believe only what they read in books. But there are natural phenomena which are not ex-plaind in any book of natural history. I accepted her explanation and from then on I listened to the sound of the green stone eater.

But now I have to tell you a totally different story. Imagine that where you are standing you start drill-ing a hole into the ground. You continue drilling to the middle of the globe and then even further until you reach the other side of the earth. Now you take a stone and let it fall into the shaft. How deep does it fall? Does it fall to the center of the globe, does



Eleanor Antin
The Death of Petronius from The
Last Days of Pompeii, 2001
Chromogenic print
46 5/8 x 94 5/8 inches

Eleanor Antin
Plaisir d'Amour (after Couture)
(from Helen's Odyssey), 2007
Chromogenic print
61 x 92 1/2 inches | 154.9 x
235 cm



Eleanor Antin
Plaisir d'Amour (after Couture)
 (from the series *Helen's Odyssey*), 2007
 Chromogenic print
 61 x 92 1/2 inches / 154.9 x 235 cm

Eleanor Antin
The Death of Petronius (from
The Last Days of Pompeii), 2001
 Chromogenic print
 46 5/8 x 94 5/8 inches

Eleanor Antin
The Golden Death (from *The
 Last Days of Pompeii*), 2001
 Chromogenic print



it come out on the other side, or what? A professor of physics may explain everything about the fall of the stone, but I am telling you that the stone falls only two feet because then it is eaten by the green stone eater. Even though I just told you a minute ago that there is an animal two feet underground which eats only stones, we were unable to make a connection between the first and the second story. I am not trying to convince you, but I persuade you to believe what I say.

The Latins made a difference between persuadere and con-vincere. Convincere is to conquer, to overcome doubt. Persuadere is to induce belief, to urge, which implies a fuller notion of changing a person in the direction of a new belief system. The change of a person's attitude is more than his conviction about a rational truth. To believe in the truth for

which you are persuaded, you must possess the a priori conditions to absorb the new message. If art is doing something to us it stirs up something in us which is already in our possession. Aes-thetic judgments are synthetic judgments which add nothing to my knowledge but rather amplify it. We need the power of intuition to create the content of what needs to be expressed at a certain moment. To connect the first story with the second one demanded intuition in order to include the stone which I throw in New York into the eating habit of the stone eater I met in Texas.

No such intuition is necessary with works which are not new in art or with works which approximate or synthesize the accomplishments of earlier art. They don't change our atti-tude because the greater works have changed us already. An enlargement

of consciousness occurs through the experience of artistic inventions which have an effect on the number of emotional channels available to us as responses to the world. What we call the spiritual in art is the message for never end-ing change in the inner human condition. The shift from one state of consciousness to another may be slow and unnotice-able or it may come suddenly, triggered by what we know as "prime events" in our emotional life: the death of a beloved, the particularly excellent performance of a piece of music, the discovery of a painting whose message had been hidden, etc. Of course, the more sensitive we are, the more varied feelings we have. Not only is art not for everyone but, also, a particular type of art may be picked up only by a few at a time. The capacity to integrate new emotional information into the es-tablished household of our existence depends on our flexibil-ity and our

Eleanor Antin
Who are we? Where are we going? (from *Roman Allegories*), 2004.
Digital print on 305gsm
Hahnemühle Photo Rag Ultra
Smooth Inkjet paper
122.9 × 152.4 cm

Eleanor Antin
The Banquet (from *The Last Days of Pompeii*), 2001
Chromogenic print
48 × 80 inches

Eleanor Antin
Judgment of Paris (after Rubens) – *Dark Helen* (from *Helen's Odyssey*), 2007
Chromogenic print
94 × 182.9 cm

willingness to take risks, which is greater the more emotional advances we were willing to make in the past. The ratio of existing emotions combined with the driving curiosity for change delimits the amount of new aesthetic information available to us at a particular time.

The concept of newness and its merit in art is a bit of a myth in itself like the report of a tornado which receives a name even before it has reached the coast. Today, new facts about art are published earlier than new art. The old resentment against change in art has been replaced by society's urge for sensationalism which stands paramount to entertainment. The entertainment industry has even swept the otherwise more quiet visual arts and created an atmosphere of hysteria which broke the distinction between a quiet and sublime apperception of art and the more folksy appearances for fast consumption. As if the distinctions between punk music and classical music wouldn't exist anymore, so, in the visual arts, everything is thrown into the same pot. The contemporary art market focuses on works which are able to stay in the spotlight. Museums, dealers, and critics try to keep up with it or, most often, abreast of it. And, symptomatic of their lightness, those works receive the highest applause which carry enough traces of the old so that their interpretation and instant acceptance is guaranteed by their superficial resemblance to an easy past. When a few decades ago society praised its architecture for being Neo-Gothic, Neo-Renaissance, Neo-Classic, it praised the old in the mediocrity of the modern. When they praise new movements today, they mostly support an army of artists who create nothing new but who seek happiness in sealing themselves in shapes borrowed from the past. Any fool can be modern today as long as he adheres to the rules of a modern academicism whose concern is the conquest of men and art. They live through the minds of other men and what they thought or did in the past. The creator's concern is not the conquest of art but the conquest of reality and particularly of nature and its manifestation in the forms which carry his substance. New forms cannot be created with conscious intentions or an aesthetic will which addresses other men or history; they result from a freedom of creation which takes past phenomena for granted without being enslaved by them. Painting is not an aesthetic but a moral enterprise. There is no linear course of history which allows the weatherman to predict the direction in which the storm is moving; anticipation must focus



on the unpredictability of the human condition and its varying energies emitted by the process of the individual coming to terms with his existence in the world.

Contemplation

Returning to the case of Van Meegeren, we now know that his attitude is a synthetic layering of the obvious features in previous styles. No art can be synthetic because all synthesis exists through the combination of previous accomplishments. Even though we can say that the works of Van Meegeren are unified by an attitude which can be denoted as style, his style reveals a mind which lives from and through past minds which have been applauded. As a result he denies us an experience through which we enlarge our consciousness because all we receive from his work are formal features, sentiments, and a choice of subject matter that belongs to previous

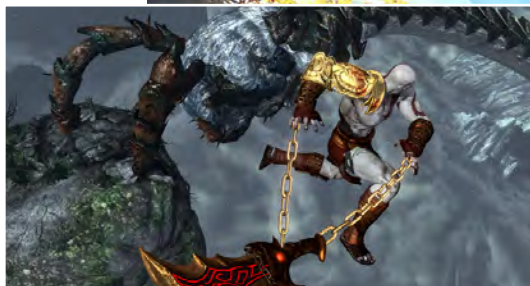
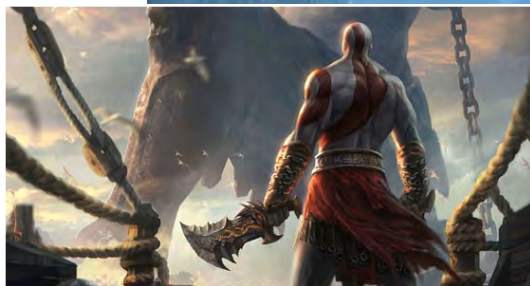
centuries. "Christ at Emmaus" is a piece of Italian laundry (the painting was said to be so great because it carried Italian influences) which found itself hanging on the same line with the linens made in Holland. How was it possible that we missed the inferior quality of the Italian linen when we knew so much about the quality of Dutch linens and particularly the brand of Vermeer? In our defense we must say that the meaning in a work cannot solely be derived from the spontaneous act of perceiving the phenomenon in front of us but from an experience and an expectation which is governed and tinted by past experience and comparison with the same or a similar class of objects. Our present experience and even perception of the object does not derive from an innocent eye but from a consciousness which is filled with the weight of past experiences and their impact for projections of the future. It follows that a work of art cannot exist in itself but as an object in relation. The relationship is threefold: first, a single work establishes a relation to the class proper to which it



Eleanor Antin
The Tree (from The Last Days of Pompeii), 2001
Chromogenic print
60 x 48 inches

Matthew Barney
CREMASTER 3, 2002
Film / video
Production still (photograph)

*Santa Monica Studio
God of War, 2018
Video game
Gameplay still*



belongs, namely, the style of an artist; second, the work or the whole style establishes a relation to the style of the time in which it was created; and third, to reality itself. At the time when Van Meegeren's "Christ at Emmaus" surfaced, a relation-ship took possession of our perception which ordered the painting into the existing class of Vermeer paintings. Today, in comparison, we possess a whole class of Van Meegeren paintings which allows us to recognize the formal features and the connected sentiments which are characteristic of his syn-thetic style. Even though his style possesses visual charac-teristics which may be contemplated and admired by millions, its aesthetic value has changed because now we don't con-template the work for its own sake and how pleasantly or unpleasantly it affects us, but we apprehend the work in terms of

an aesthetic value which constitutes a more complete devel-opment and consummation of the object in an act of looking for the sake of an experience and knowledge of art and the world. In our first encounter with Van Meegeren's painting the weight of our knowledge and our expectation to include it in the line of Vermeer distracted us from the truth, our own truth, about the visual characteristics contemplated in Ver-meer. We did not properly contemplate the minor painting because our contemplation was interrupted by the great myth which the opinion of the world had laid upon the phenome-non in front of us. We had in fact succumbed to the myth created by society before we approached the visual myth in a painting.

Some lightweight aestheticians are claiming today that an object, any object, becomes a work of art as long as the art world has elevated it into the state of art. The paintings of the chimpanzee Betsy in the Chicago Zoo could become art as long as the curator of the Chicago Art Institute is willing to christen these products art and display them on the walls of his museum. Such an argument confuses the ontological posi-tion of a phenomenon with its social standing. We sense that our judgment about a work should not derive from adherence to a myth which the public might have built for it but that the value of a work should ontologically be contained in it as an objective necessity, equal to a truth which is superindividual, universal, and eternal. That the style of an artist is original and powerful does not depend on the subjective disposition of an onlook-



*David Jaffe
God of War II, 2007
Video game
Gameplay still*

Any visual appearance has the potential to convey a feeling which we connect with the spiritual. It is however not spirituality as such which needs to be grasped but the type of 'spirituality' which expresses itself in the particularity of 'a feeling'. Any attempt to develop a scheme of forms which would guarantee the spir-itual must fail. There are no a priori rules and regulations regarding the creation of the spiritual through a canon of form. Every painting, even the worst, possesses the potential for the spir-itual. But because it is the type of spirituality which is the message of the artist for art no formal criteria hold true for all of art. Formal analysis can occur post facto only. I can establish how Raphael paints and what his formal categories are, but nothing that I say about Raphael may hold true for Rembrandt or any other painter. It is more likely that every-thing I say for the greatness of Raphael may be terrible in Rembrandt. And similarly, I cannot ask who is a greater spir-itual painter, Rothko or Pollock, because we are dealing with different types of feelings, all of which constitute a type of spirituality for which my own condition shows a predilection. In this sense the history of art cannot be considered a history of actual values-there is also no reason to believe that the best necessarily survives-but rather it is a basket full with the greatest myth of individual artists, the vision which all the masters have created for themselves and for the glory of man.



Matthew Barney
CREMASTER 3, 2002
Film / video (single-channel)
Film still / documentation image
Matthew Barney



Interview with Wangechi Mutu

Wangechi Mutu is a Kenyan-born, New York-based artist whose work is renowned for its forceful critique of power, politics and identity. With a multi-disciplinary practice that spans drawing, collage, video and performance, Mutu creates fantastical and surreal landscapes that challenge the dominant narratives of the Western art world. Through her unique visual language, she draws upon a rich tapestry of cultural and historical references and her own experiences as a diasporic African woman to explore the intersections of race, gender and colonialism, while also drawing attention to the complexities of the human condition.

Mixing sensuality and violence, Mutu's work is equally seductive and disturbing, speaking directly to the viewers' subconscious and inviting them to question their own perceptions. Her work has been displayed in major exhibitions and galleries around the world, including the Metropolitan Museum of Art, the Fine Arts Museum of San Francisco and the Centre Georges Pompidou.

Michele Fossi: One of the most striking elements of your art is the way you represent women. Your female figures are often depicted through collage techniques

as powerful, larger-than-life beings with exaggerated features and poses. Strong, assertive, unapologetic, and sometimes even threatening, they challenge traditional notions of femininity and beauty. Who are they, and what do they represent to you?

Wangechi Mutu: Growing up around strong African black women, my work celebrates them and what they have helped me achieve. This is my way of honouring and praising all the strong black women throughout the centuries who helped us get to this point in history. We all originated from African ancestors; every single one of us comes from the same common black mother. Dispersions and migrations began thousands of years ago with people migrating from their motherland to colder, less sunny regions or to other faraway continents. Despite our differences, we are all part of the same homo sapiens species.

Michele: How did you develop this strong interest in the black female figure?

Wangechi Mutu
Bloody Rug, 2025
Handwoven silk rug
106 x 244 in / 269.2 x 365.8 cm

Wangechi: I attended a Catholic all-girls school where I was surrounded by female teachers, female students and images of the Virgin Mary. This immersive environment, steeped in feminine energy, has been an enduring source of inspiration for me. I view feminine energy as a universal aspect of humanity, one I continually attempt to incorporate into my works.

Michele: What led you to choose collage as your artistic medium at the beginning of your career?

Wangechi: I chose collage as my medium because it was the most accessible and impactful way for me to create. When I moved to New York and aimed to become a serious artist, I lacked the resources for expensive materials. I started experimenting with magazine clippings and watercolours, which led to unexpected surprises and a sense of tension that I sought in the creation process. By combining these elements, I was able to create something new that even I had to understand.

Michele: Is it possible for you to quickly walk us through some of the most unusual materials you use in your collages and explain their function?

Wangechi: I have worked with milk, wine, high heels, soil, trash bags, tea leaves, hair nets, buttons, cow horns, shells, moths, panties, and crystals to represent the beauty and potential of this diverse world.

Michele: What about the photographic material you incorporate, mostly portraying black women?

Wangechi: The majority of the photographic elements in my collages were sourced from fashion magazines. I then expanded my search to include other types of magazines, moving away from the idealised and homogenous depictions of women in glossy glamour magazines. I observed how skin types were portrayed differently based on the intended audience and what was being sold. This sparked a creative challenge for me, as I sought to subvert the original narrative and craft something dignified, beautiful and alluring from images that once bothered me.



Michele: Your female figures exude an otherworldly and surreal quality, enhanced by the incorporation of human and animal features, such as women with hyena heads or manta ray bodies.

Wangechi: The blending of human and animal elements is as old as the human imagination itself. Throughout history, humans have been enamoured with the elegant grace, speed and raw strength of certain creatures, and have often sought to embody these qualities in their own form. My art is deeply inspired by the natural world and I am particularly drawn to the ways in which all living beings, including humans, animals and plants, are interconnected and interdependent on this crowded planet. Despite the destruction wrought by humans, if you take the time to observe and contemplate, it becomes clear that all living creatures, animals, people and plants stem from a common origin and share the earth's resources.

Michele: In 2014, at Victoria Miro Gallery, you showed *Sleeping Serpent*, a fabric and ceramic sculpture over ten metres long, of a snake with a woman's head. Such human-snake hybrid creatures are recurrent in your work. What are they?

Wangechi: They are inspired by the real-life giant sea cow known as the nguva, which is native to East Africa and has become increasingly rare due to overhunting. In local folklore, these marine animals are intertwined with mythology, being believed to possess the ability to transform into mermaid-like human forms. The belief in these magical creatures is becoming less widespread, with fewer people in Kenya openly discussing the mermaids. In the past, sightings of beautiful new women in a village would often be met with whispered warnings of 'She must be a nguva.'

Michele: No less mesmerising are *The Seated*, four bronze sculptures you created for the Met's facade niches in September

Wangechi Mutu
Subterranea Panthera, 2021
Ink, emulsion paint and watercolour
paper on photographic print
202.5 x 140 x 6 cm

Wangechi Mutu
Riding Death in My Sleep, 2002
Ink and collage on paper



Wangechi Mutu
Subterranea Fairy 2021
Ink and emulsion paint on photo-
graphic print
102.5 x 140 x 6 cm

2019, a space that has been vacant since the museum was built. Titled The New Ones, will free Us, the works consist of two kneeling and two seated female figures, exuding regal power. They have been described as ‘simultaneously celestial and humanoid, strange and familiar’, as well as ‘the culmination of two decades of sustained artistic experimentation and rigorous research into the relationship between power, race, gender, and representation’. What inspired the idea for this special commission?

Wangechi: When the Met approached me with this opportunity, I delved into the study of the caryatid sculptures housed in their museum. Historically, caryatids were used to showcase the power and wealth of a particular place through their supporting role in architecture. This idea is echoed in African sculptures, which frequently feature sitting or kneeling female figures holding up the throne of a king and sometimes even a child. Upon realising that this was a typical portrayal of women across various cultures and time periods, I wondered how I could use this figure to challenge and subvert these cultural norms. I wanted to retain the strong and active pose of the woman, but I did not want her to be burdened with carrying the weight of something or someone else.

Michele: What are those coils and discs decorating them?

Wangechi: I’ve incorporated coils that wrap around the female figures to give them a tactile and fleshy quality. At the same time, these coils provide a sense of protection and privacy, giving the women a regal and almost armoured appearance. The discs that adorn their bodies were inspired by the stunning lip plates worn by women of high status in Ethiopian and Sudanese tribes. In my interpretation these disks serve as mirrors, reflecting and twisting light to captivate the viewer from a distance.

Michele: You divide your time between two studios, one in New York and one in Nairobi. Are there similarities between the two?

Wangechi: Both my Nairobi studio and the New York studio are filled with similar material: photo-

graphic books about Africa’s history and traditions, pictures of current affairs, magazines, et cetera. The walls, which I see as thinking space, are also usually filled with images. The main difference between the two is that I am surrounded by natural soil, rocks and plants in Nairobi. To get the supplies for my work I just need to walk out the door of the studio.

Michele: You are known for having a very intimate relationship with your studio.

Wangechi: My studio is a crucial part of my daily routine, it’s where I feel the most focused and comfortable. Only my close family and assistant are allowed in, creating an intimate atmosphere. The fact that my studio is close to my home adds to its significance in my life, serving as both the heart and soul of my daily existence. I view my studio as a sacred space, where I can think and create in a different manner than I do in other environments. It is a mental space that stimulates my imagination, and I consider it a place to be honoured and respected.

Michele: As a Kenyan-born artist residing in the US, has your nostalgia for Kenya influenced your art, and if so, how?

Wangechi: My work often reflects feelings of nostalgia, saudade and ennui. It’s difficult to depart from one’s home country, especially when the future is uncertain. I find myself frequently missing my childhood home and the memories associated with it. The plants, flowers and creatures in my work are sourced from these memories, representing a longing for a time that no longer exists.

Michele: Staying on the topic of interiors, the theme of this issue of Acne Paper is ‘House’. What memories do you have of your childhood house?

Wangechi: My family and I lived in a little one-story bungalow surrounded by a garden. I remember playing on the dry grass with our toys, sometimes in areas of the garden where we weren’t supposed to. It was a bit of a wild space, where we got very dirty. The memories I have of that time have influenced the way I work today.

Michele: You seem to draw a lot of inspiration from that little girl playing on the grass in your

Wangechi Mutu
The Seated I, 2019
Bronze
Sculpture



Wangechi: The concept behind this piece was to bring a collage to life in four dimensions. As I worked on it I realised that what I'd created was more than just a monster – it was like a moon or a planet. This creature symbolises human evolution, as well as consumption, greed and industrialisation. In the end, exhausted, it consumes itself until oblivion, and collapses in its own waste and smoke.C

Michele: The animated video 'The End of carrying All', first presented during the Venice Biennale in 2015, features a female figure who is carrying a large, cumbersome burden on her shoulders. The figure's journey is meant to comment on the experiences of women and people of colour, who are often burdened with societal expectations and injustices.

Wangechi: The burden the woman carries – a symbol of labour as well as the struggles of civilisation and industrialisation – becomes increasingly heavy. On her head, she carries a radio tower, a large TV dish, an apartment building, an oil rig, and more. As she travels through a stunning sunset landscape, she eventually collapses from exhaustion. Despite this, she continues to move forward, even resorting to crawling. At this point, we realise that what we are witnessing is not just the representation of man-made problems, but something else entirely – a growing anomaly that ultimately overflows and engulfs her.

artistic practice. You frequently incorporate 'fragments of Nature' and other found materials into your work to emphasise the cyclical nature of life and the interdependence of all living things, and to explore themes of birth, growth, decay and renewal, while also commenting on the impact of human behaviour on the environment.

Wangechi: As an artist, I have a strong belief in the transformative power of collage. By taking pieces of nature, like trees and animals, and anonymous yet recognisable objects and placing them in my work, I aim to magnify their energy and essence. By incorporating them into my art, I aim to highlight the importance of every living being in maintaining a delicate balance in our ecosystem. Through my work, I strive to amplify the significance of each plant, animal and human, and to showcase the interconnectedness of all life.

Michele: Inorganic material such as soil and mud also often appears in your mixed-media collages and sculptures as a symbol of the connection between humans and the natural world, as well as a metaphor for identity and cultural heritage.

Wangechi: Soil has become important for me and this Nairobi studio because I actually identify with the soil. Soil that I remember from my childhood, the colour of the soil, the feeling of the soil, the texture, the way it behaves when it's dry, when it's wet, when it rains. In New York, I don't feel that same sense of identification with the soil. I don't trust the soil. I always think that there are other things going on in this soil that I haven't put in and weren't put in there in the first place by nature. So there is a certain diffidence between me and the ground. Whereas here I tend to

immediately want to capture the essence of the soil, the malleability, the colour, the crispness, the granular aspects. All of those things are important for me in the work.

Michele: You also produced a few impressive animated videos. The first one, called 'The End of eating Everything', was created in collaboration with recording artist Santigold and co-released by the Nasher Museum of Art at Duke University in 2013. It shows the journey of a monstrous, flying, planet-like creature with a beautiful female face, navigating a bleak and polluted sky-scape and relentlessly devouring birds. Is it a representation of humanity's omnivorous appetite for things in the world?

Artist





Wangechi Mutu

Wangechi Mutu was born in 1972 in Nairobi, Kenya. In her collages, drawings, sculptures, and films, Mutu centers the female body to create powerful and self-possessed figures that are hybrids of human, plant, animal, and machine forms. Sampling from a diverse array of sources—from natural materials to fashion magazines, medical diagrams, and traditional African arts—the artist creates otherworldly realms that examine cultural identity, the feminine, colonial history, and global consumption.

First recognized for her collage paintings, Mutu began her career combining ink and paint with fragments of images mined from fashion magazines, National Geographic, and vintage illustrations. With these materials, Mutu constructs elegant yet perverse female characters that subvert the ways in

which Black and female bodies have been depicted, packaged, and consumed. The figures simultaneously embody the disjointed experience of navigating transnational identity, contemporary Africa, and Western preconceptions. Working extensively on nonabsorbent Mylar film, Mutu maneuvers colorful ink and paint on the surfaces of these works to build a fantastically dense and textured ground. In her varied sculpture practice, Mutu utilizes natural materials such as paper pulp and Kenyan soil while also working in monumental bronze. For her Sentinel series (2016–present), the artist creates regal and fierce abstract female forms made from clay, wood, and various found materials. Mutu describes these towering sculptures as guarding the very earth that they are made from; they serve as reminders of our relationship to the planet and harbingers of our environmental crisis. Mutu’s bronze works, such as *The NewOnes*, will free *Us* (2019) and *MamaRay* (2020), are supernatural humanoid figures that contest the traditional roles of women in art and propose alternative iconography and modes of representation as well as potential futures. “I create as a way of reinvigorating myself by replacing and reworking images and ideas that never fully represented me and the women and the people I was born from and who made me,” Wangechi Mutu has said.

Wangechi Mutu
Riding Death in My Sleep, 2002
Ink and collage on paper

Wangechi Mutu
Yo Mama, 2003
Ink, mica flakes, acrylic, pressure-sensitive film, cut-and-pasted printed paper, and painted paper on paper, diptych
59 1/8 × 85 in | 150.2 × 215.9 cm



“I’m trying to just push up the volume on how incredibly important every single plant, and animal, and human is in keeping us all alive and afloat.”

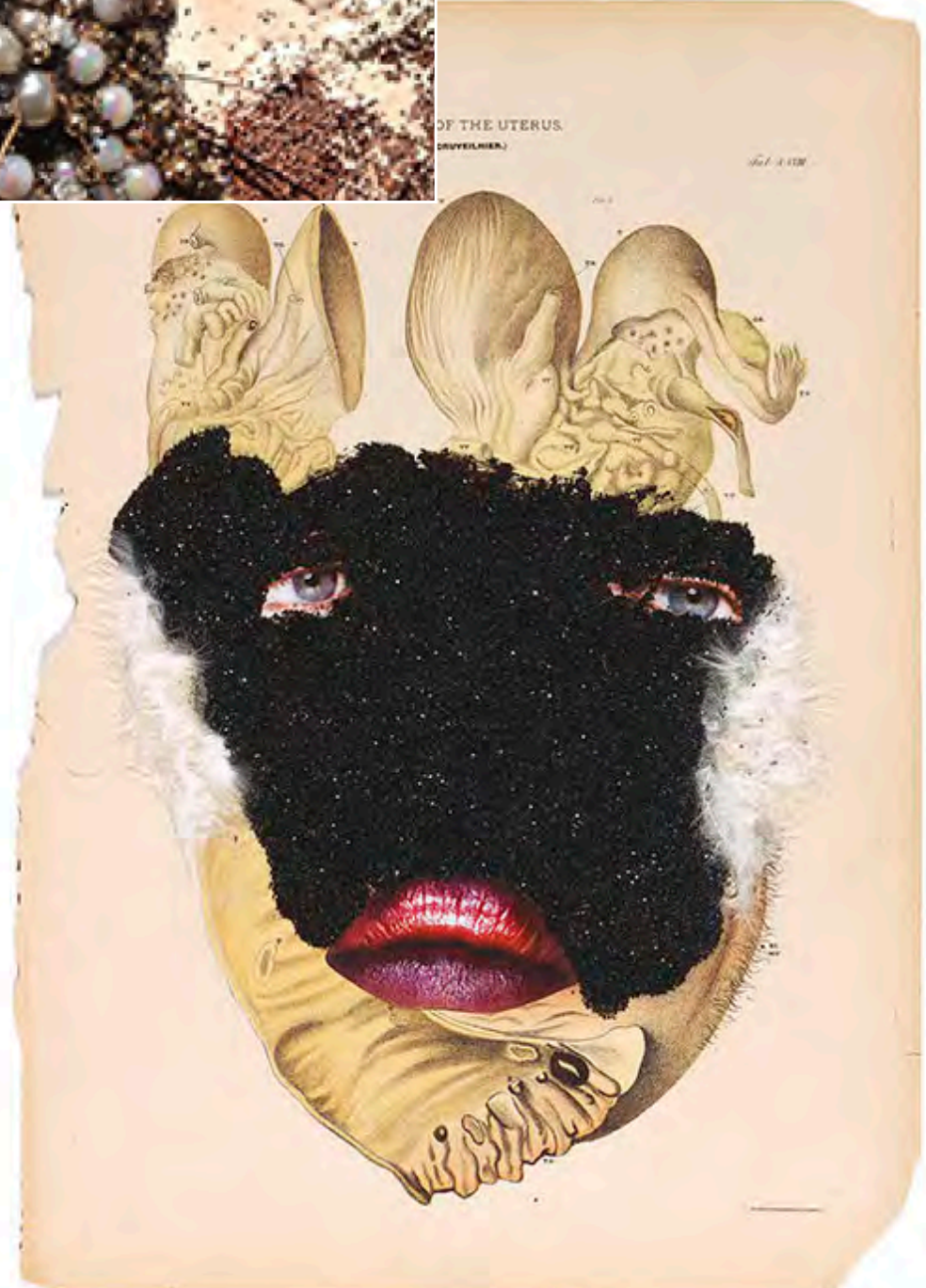
Wangechi Mutu
Water Spirit Washed Pelican, 2022
Lithograph, collage, and mica on archival pigment print

Wangechi Mutu
Lizard Love, 2006
Mixed media, ink, spray paint, and collage on Mylar

Wangechi Mutu
Lizard Love, 2006
Mixed media, ink, spray paint, and collage on Mylar
25 x 21 1/2 in | 63.5 x 54.6 cm

Wangechi Mutu
 Yo Mama, 2003
 Ink, mica flakes, acrylic, pressure-sensitive film, cut-and-pasted printed paper, and painted paper on paper, diptych
 59 1/8 x 85 in | 150.2 x 215.9 cm

Wangechi Mutu
 Double Fuse (panels 1 & 2), 2003
 Ink and collage on Mylar
 25 1/2 x 19 1/2 in each | 64.8 x 49.5 cm each





Wangechi Mutu
*Misguided Little Unforgivable
 Hierarchies*, 2005
 Ink, acrylic, collage, and mixed media
 on Mylar
 40 × 26 inches / 101.6 × 66 cm

Wangechi Mutu
Double Fuse (panels 1 & 2), 2003
 Ink and collage on Mylar



Qiu Anxiong

Qiu Anxiong
The New Book of Mountains and
Seas, 2006–2017
Ink animation video (still image)
Single-channel video

In ancient times, artists were essentially craftsmen. Think of the Longmen Grottoes or the Dunhuang murals: today we see them as masterpieces and protect them carefully, but back then, the people who made them were craftsmen.

By the Song dynasty, the status of artists rose dramatically—because an artist became an emperor: Emperor Huizong of Song, the one who basically lost the Northern Song. As an emperor he was a failed politician, but artistically he achieved a great deal. Here is one of his bird-and-flower paintings; his calligraphy and painting were truly distinctive.

Not only was he a strong artist himself, he also established what may be the only academy system of its kind in China—or even in the world: a government-created institution for art. Under his influence, many major artistic traditions and trends took shape from the Song dynasty onward—landscape painting, literati painting, and so on.

Hundreds of years later, in the West during the Renaissance, works like Leonardo da Vinci's Mona Lisa helped elevate the status of artists enormously. Here is Michelangelo's David.

Artists were no longer merely craftsmen. They were regarded as geniuses—figures who could be spoken of alongside poets and philosophers. In today's terms, they were elite intellectuals.

When we look at earlier artworks like these, we can immediately tell what they are. A sculpture is a person; we can feel the skill, the realism—these things are direct and intuitive.

But later, especially from the late 19th century and into the 20th century—modern art—things began to change fast, and the shifts became dramatic. Monet's Impression, Sunrise, Cézanne's still lifes—

Hello everyone. When I meet a stranger, they often ask, "So what do you do?" My answer is: I'm an artist. If they have a bit of interest in art, the next question is usually, "Oh—do you paint oil paintings?" And then I hesitate. If they ask, "So you paint traditional Chinese painting?" I say, not really. After thinking for a second, I realize it's actually kind of complicated to explain.

So I keep it simple: I make animation. Then they'll say, "Oh, like Pleasant Goat and Big Big Wolf?" And I say, not that either. So for me, it's a question that's genuinely hard to answer.

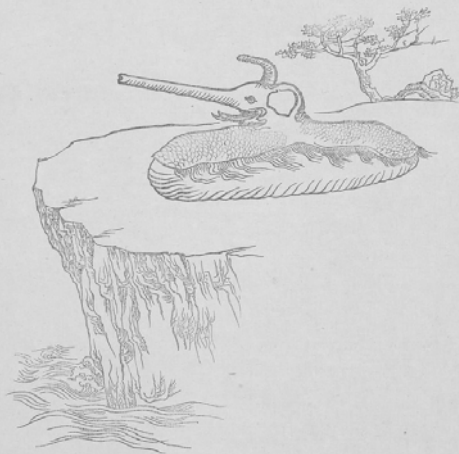
The identity "artist" sounds like a big word today, but if we trace its origins—say, back to ancient Greece—they created remarkable sculptures and paintings, yet their social status was not that high.



【廷獨】

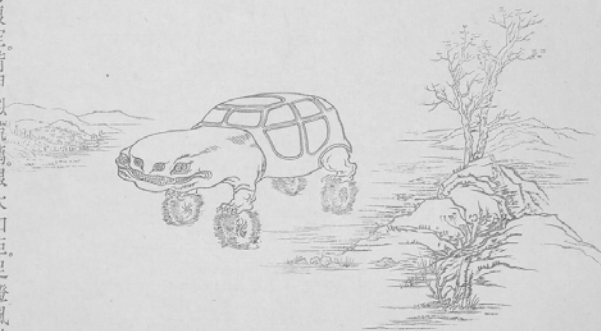


海底數千里，體黑皮堅，眼生背鰭之端，背有孔，常名曰廷獨。



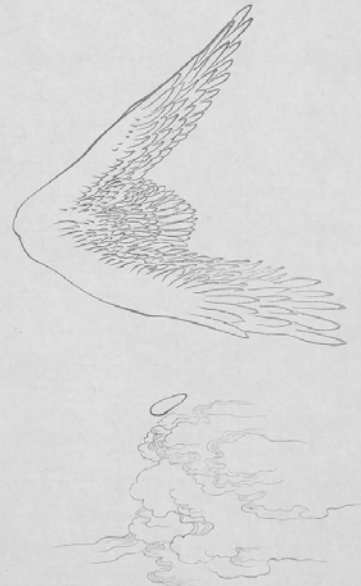
西方之土有獸焉，象頭牛身，無足，頭生其背，身被堅甲，腹行甚速，鼻直，可噴火，其名曰唐坦。

阿美利坎洲始有獸，頭扁腹空，背甲似琉璃，眼大如炬，足蹬風輪，不食而飲油，日行千里，勝於駿馬，今世人皆取之，其名曰敖駝，又名奇轍。



【敖駝】

阿美利坎洲有巨鳥焉，無頭，其翼長大，飛於雲上極高之處，不棲他處，棲息必同巢，人罕能見之，空中生卵，入地即生雷，所觸盡為灰燼，其名曰必圖。



【必圖】

“For me, I like to look at the relationship between people and nature using a variation of angles.”

Qiu Anxiong
The New Book of Mountains and Seas, 2006–2017
Ink animation video (still image)
Single-channel video

Qiu Anxiong
The New Book of Mountains and Seas (Mythical Creature), 2006–2017
Ink on paper animation drawing
Video still



these are still fairly clear to us; we know them as Impressionism and post-Impressionism.

This is Van Gogh's *Starry Night*. Everyone knows it, but it already doesn't look like the starry sky we see with our own eyes.

And here is Picasso. He painted a woman; the title is *The Weeping Woman*. Why would he paint a woman like this? We often say art is about beauty—but is this beautiful?

This is Kandinsky, one of the founders of abstract art.

When people who aren't familiar with modern and contemporary art see paintings like this, their faces might look like...

Is this painting good? What makes it good? What's the difference between this and a child's scribbles on a blackboard? This is a work by the important American artist Cy Twombly. How is it good? I won't explain it—I'll just tell you it's worth ten million US dollars. Then people go, "Oh. But why?"

Performance art has become a kind of loaded term in China. If someone says they do performance art, people might just laugh—everything goes without saying, as if there must be something wrong with them.

This is also a performance artist: Joseph Beuys, an important German artist after World War II. He proposed a concept, or a slogan: "Everyone is an artist."

Qiu Anxiong
The New Book of Mountains and Seas, 2006–2017
Ink animation video (still image)
Single-channel video

Qiu Anxiong
The New Book of Mountains and Seas (Mythical Creature), 2006–2017
Ink on paper animation drawing
Video still



At this point, the definition of “artist” seems to become more and more blurred. What does it mean, “everyone is an artist”? It’s like entering a communist society—everyone has immense creativity, everyone can create new things. It sounds like a very utopian artistic ideal.

Similarly, Beuys proposed the idea of “social sculpture.” What is social sculpture? He believed that society itself is a work made by humanity; everyone’s actions influence society and sculpt it. In other words, he understood all human action as a kind of creative act.

If we see it this way, then “artist” is no longer a specialized label—no longer only for a few people with extraordinary talent or genius. Anyone can be an artist, or everyone has the potential to be an artist.

But is that really true? After that, an American philosopher, Arthur Danto, who studied the philosophy of art, put forward another idea: he said art has ended. Why would he say that? Didn’t we just say everyone is an artist—so how can art be over?

Of course, once someone raises a question like this, many people will have different thoughts and opinions. I’m an artist—if I agreed with that conclusion, I’d be pretty miserable. This profession would be impossible to continue.

Along with the confusion around the word “artist,” there’s also a broader confusion about contemporary art itself. Today we’re giving a talk in a museum of contemporary art. Honestly, contemporary art, as I see it today, really does have some problems. The first big problem is that it can be extremely hard to understand.

Here is a work by a British artist. What do you think it is? Yes—it’s a paper ball. Nothing special: just an A4 sheet of paper crumpled into a ball, and it becomes an artwork.

Why can a crumpled paper ball be an artwork? If crumpling a paper ball can be an artwork—maybe even a pretty good one—doesn’t that mean everyone can be an artist? Because anyone can crumple paper.

But the paper ball you crumple might not be an artwork. So what’s the difference? His paper ball is displayed in a museum; yours gets thrown into a

trash can. That’s the only difference. When art develops to this point, it can make us feel confused. What can art still bring us?

Of course, that’s a huge question. Unfortunately, I ended up working in art, so I have to face it too. For me, if I create art—what am I bringing to others? I think about that question.

I studied fine art in an academy. At first it was drawing and color, then all kinds of modeling techniques, then ideas and art history—learning about the development of human art as a whole. And does it all ultimately add up to this: that I can crumple a paper ball and bring it to everyone? Is that the final result?

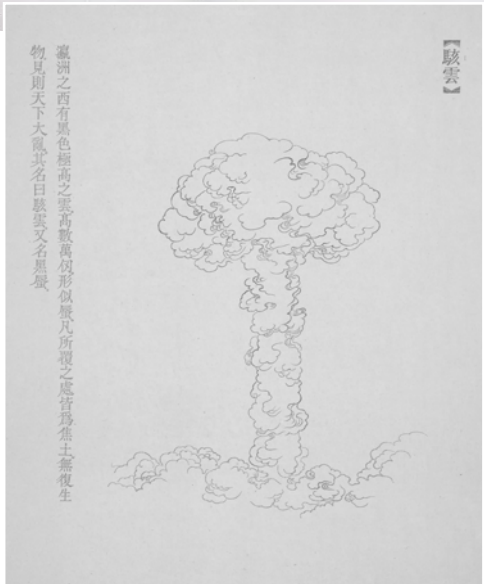
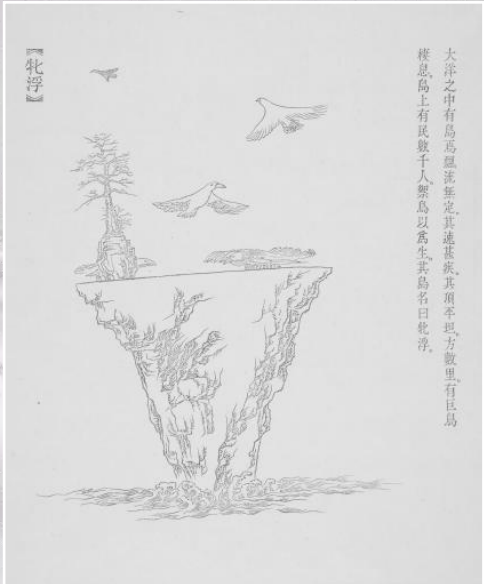
Slowly, I went from not understanding, to doubting, to feeling lost. I didn’t know what I should do. In the end, maybe you still have to find what you’re truly interested in—and not care whether it’s fashionable in today’s context, not care whether it’s something “in trend.” I needed to find what I was genuinely interested in.



Qiu Anxiong
The New Book of Mountains and Seas, 2006–2017
Ink animation video (still image)
Single-channel video

Qiu Anxiong
The New Book of Mountains and Seas (Mythical Creature), 2006–2017
Ink on paper animation drawing
Video still





Qiu Anxiong
The New Book of Mountains and
Seas, 2006–2017
Ink animation video (still image)
Single-channel video

Qiu Anxiong
The New Book of Mountains
and Seas (Mythical Creature),
2006–2017
Ink on paper animation drawing
Video still



Qiu Anxiong
The New Book of Mountains and
Seas, 2006–2017
Ink animation video (still image)
Single-channel video

Qiu Anxiong
The New Book of Mountains
and Seas (Mythical Creature),
2006–2017
Ink on paper animation drawing
Video still

Kara Walker

*Kara Walker
Inaugural Fantasia, 2025
Watercolor and sumi-e ink on cut
paper on paper*

*Kara Walker
The Colonists' Day of Judge-
ment, 2020
Walnut ink, shell white, pen, ink,
and watercolor on paper*

viewing season!...,” (the title is too long to reproduce in full) presents a set of new and urgently drawn canvases and works on paper. Among them, *The (Private) Memorial Garden of Grandison Harris* (2017), tackles that enigmatic figure with the tenderness and repulsion we’ve come to expect from Walker. Overseen by a white silhouette in tattered clothes, sparingly modeled in streaks of grey, Harris appears in paper cutout spanning the join between the two linen canvases that form the diptych of the large collage. Slouched against him is the corpse of a black woman, and Harris appears to fondle her bare breasts as he drags her from the rhomboid silhouette that delineates her empty grave. What Walker offers us in this confused fall is a genre of art we may not be so accustomed to seeing: history painting.

History painting was, from the 17th to 19th centuries, considered the highest vocation of art, superior to the lesser forms of landscape and portraiture. History, of course, was both real and imagined: the battles of empires, the myths of antiquity, biblical tales. This was a field of production dominated by harsh strictures over subject matter, style, and the conditions of production. The genre fell out of style in the late 19th Century when the givens of European societies were cast into doubt after the upheaval of the industrial revolution, and artists began the project of self-criticism of the norms and standards of their field, a project we know today as Modernism. It was a project of interrogating all those formal and social strictures—the realism of the picture plane, the elevation of subjects—so that they might be loosened or discarded, a project that may have appeared complete in the later 20th century when “the end of history” was loudly proclaimed, when the so-called grand narratives that the modernists both owed their existence to and ruthlessly interrogated were declared crumbled and gone.

But today’s art world has its strictures just the same, albeit in new forms. The stories that reign in

Grandison Harris is an obscure figure in American history, one who evades the titles of hero, villain, or victim. First as a slave, then as an employed freedman of the Georgia Medical College, Harris was a resurrection man—a grave robber. As a slave he was granted the rare and illegal privilege of literacy (deemed necessary by the college’s faculty for him to read death announcements and discover gravesites), and as a freedman used that literacy to ascend to a short-lived post as town judge and longer-lived position of influence in his community. Until his retirement in 1913, Harris continued to dig up corpses, often those of black men and women, an activity that earned him suspicion in the very community into which he had ascended.

Harris is a fitting subject for Kara Walker, whose career dredges up the rotting corpses of history rather than tell neat tales or grant reassurances. Her offering this fall, “Sikkema Jenkins and Co. is Compelled to present the most Astounding and Important Painting show of the fall Art Show



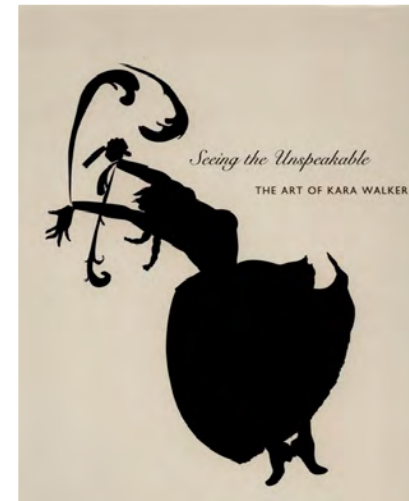
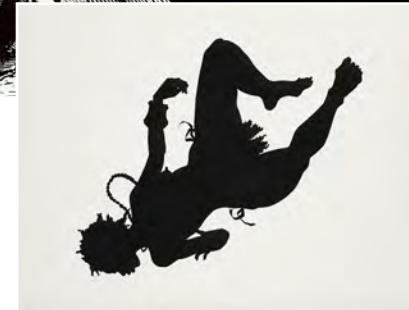


the present are written not back into time but onto space and skin; they operate at the level of identity. Walker knows this all too well. When, in the weeks preceding her show at Sikkema Jenkins, Walker wrote in an artist's statement that she is "tired, true, of being a featured member of [her] racial group and/or gender niche," she was met with immediate backlash for her refusal to take a stand. Her critics assailed her for creating work that responds to issues of race and gender, but denying their interpretation as political signposts. What these critics misunderstood is that they are of course free to interpret her work however they like, even to position it as a rallying point. But Walker herself, much like the characters she depicts, does not wish to be made into a political hero. To position Walker's art as a political statement would rob it of its rich complexity and uncomfortable contradictions. Her plea to be judged as what she is—an artist—revealed the tragic difficulty of such a thing for a talented artist who happened to be born in dark skin and a female body. We may have done away with that old hierarchy of subject matter and prescription of form, but art today is dominated by a complex rubric of who can say what and how those statements might be received.



Kara Walker
The Keys to the Coop, 1997
Linocut on paper
46 × 60 1/2 in | 116.8 × 153.7 cm

Kara Walker
Christ's Entry into Journalism, 2017
Cut paper and ink on paper



How does sound carry history? What does history sound like?

Kara Walker
Exodus of Confederates from
Atlanta, from Harper's Pictorial
History of the Civil War (Anno-
tated), 2005
Offset lithography and silkscreen
on Somerset textured paper
39 x 59 in | 99.1 x 149.9 cm

Kara Walker
African/American, 1998
Linocut
44 x 62 in | 111.8 x 157.5 cm

Kara Walker
Seeing the Unspeakable: The Art
of Kara Walker, 2004
Offset print (poster)
Dimensions variable



Kara Walker
Slaughter of the Innocents (They
Might Be Guilty of Something),
2016
Cut paper, acrylic, and graphite
on canvas
79 × 220 in | 200.7 × 558.8 cm



Kara Walker
A Subtlety, 2014
Installation
Installation view / documentation
image

Helen Chadwick

*Helen Chadwick
Allegory of Misrule, 1986
Photomontage
Dimensions variable*

*Helen Chadwick
Of Mutability, 1986
Photographic textile installation
Dimensions variable*



'I was trying to open up a territory for desire, how to depict desire and physical sensation and pleasure. And given that one's experience of that is through the body, it seemed that the body was central to the project,' explained the artist Helen Chadwick (1953–1996) in an interview. Her words speak to the core concerns of her artistic practice, which embraced the corporeal.

Unafraid of strong odours and sludge, Chadwick is known for employing a vast range of materials in surprising ways, incorporating bodily fluids, meat, flowers, chocolate, and compost into her works. Through her unconventional approach to artmaking, Chadwick quickly established herself as a leading figure amongst Britain's post-war avant-garde, becoming one of the first women artists to be nominated for the Turner Prize.

Although she was widely exhibited during her lifetime, attention to her work has declined following

her unexpected death at the age of 42. A multidisciplinary artist who embraced risk and experimentation, Chadwick left behind a rich body of work that is ripe for rediscovery by new generations of art enthusiasts.

Born in Croydon to a Greek mother and British father, Chadwick expressed profound curiosity in the world around her from a young age, and she would allegedly spend childhood afternoons peering into the lens of her microscope. Though she initially planned to study archaeology and anthropology, Chadwick applied to art school at the last minute, a decision that sealed her fate. While her love of artmaking ultimately prevailed, her preoccupation with materiality and human culture persisted, materialising in the diverse works she produced.

Early projects from her time as a student express a feminist perspective steeped in criticality and humour. Her mixed-media work *Menstrual Piece*

(1976) and performance *Domestic Sanitation* (1976) consider how gender roles are reinforced – and contested – through architectural space and clothing, respectively.

For her MA graduation project, *In the Kitchen* (1977), Chadwick created wearable sculptures representing household appliances, which she fabricated from metal frames and soft PVC ‘skins’. These objects doubled as costumes that Chadwick and her classmates wore during performances for live audiences and the camera.

By merging women’s bodies with kitchen equipment, Chadwick’s work satirises the domestic roles women were expected to ‘naturally’ inhabit. Constricted by the metal structures, the women’s

bodies become machinic, while the objects in turn become bodily, with the stovetop mirroring breasts and the door of the washer-spin dryer recalling a pregnant belly. This attention to intersections between the physical, social, and representational would go on to define her practice.

Following graduation, Chadwick began teaching at art schools across London, including Goldsmiths, where she worked alongside fellow instructors Mark Wallinger, Michael Craig-Martin, and Judith Cowan. While there, she mentored a younger generation of artists, including members of the Young British Artists. Among her students, she was known for her sharp intellect and sleek haircuts. Her influence can be felt in Sarah Lucas’ use of meat and intestinal forms and Anya Gallaccio’s work with chocolate and flowers.

After a self-described ‘sociological phase’ in her practice, Chadwick felt the urge to begin a more autobiographical project recentring her own body and experiences. In *Ego Geometria Sum* (1982–1983), Chadwick constructed a series of ten wooden sculptures each portraying a different stage of life, represented by geometric forms printed with photographic images. Created when she was 30, the series of sculptures traces key milestones in the artist’s development during her three decades of life. According to Chadwick, the works ‘offer evidence of the passage of time, the effects and constraining influence of socialisation.’

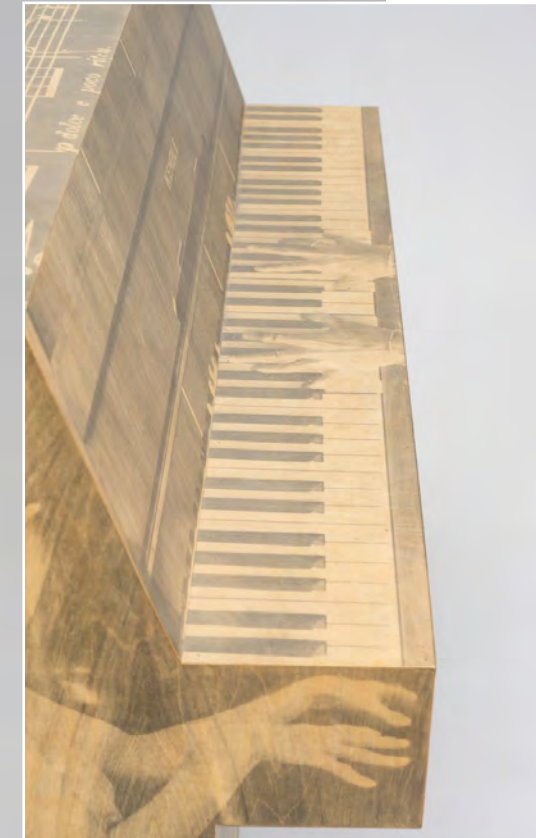
At times, Chadwick’s work inspired controversy due to her non-traditional choice of materials and subject matter. Even certain feminists were uneasy

with Chadwick’s celebratory representations of her nude body, and suggested they reproduced sexist stereotypes. These criticisms rankled Chadwick, as she was keenly aware of the politics of the ‘male gaze’ and felt her work presented women as subjects, rather than objects of desire.



Helen Chadwick
Piss Flowers, 1991–92
Sculpture, cast bronze and enamel
Dimensions variable

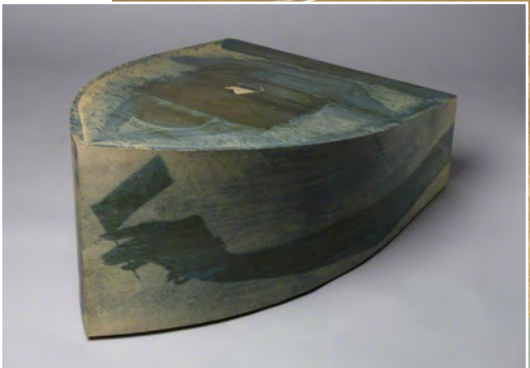
Helen Chadwick
Ego Geometria Sum, 1982–84
Photographic series with
sculptural objects (plywood,
photographs, mixed media)
Dimensions variable



Helen Chadwick
Ego Geometria Sum, 1982–84
 Photographic series with
 sculptural objects (plywood,
 photographs, mixed media)
 Dimensions variable



Helen Chadwick
Ego Geometria Sum, 1982–84
 Photographic series with
 sculptural objects (plywood,
 photographs, mixed media)
 Dimensions variable



Matthew Barney

Matthew Barney
CREMASTER 5, 1997
Film / video
Production still

Matthew Barney
CREMASTER 1, 1995
Film / video
Production still



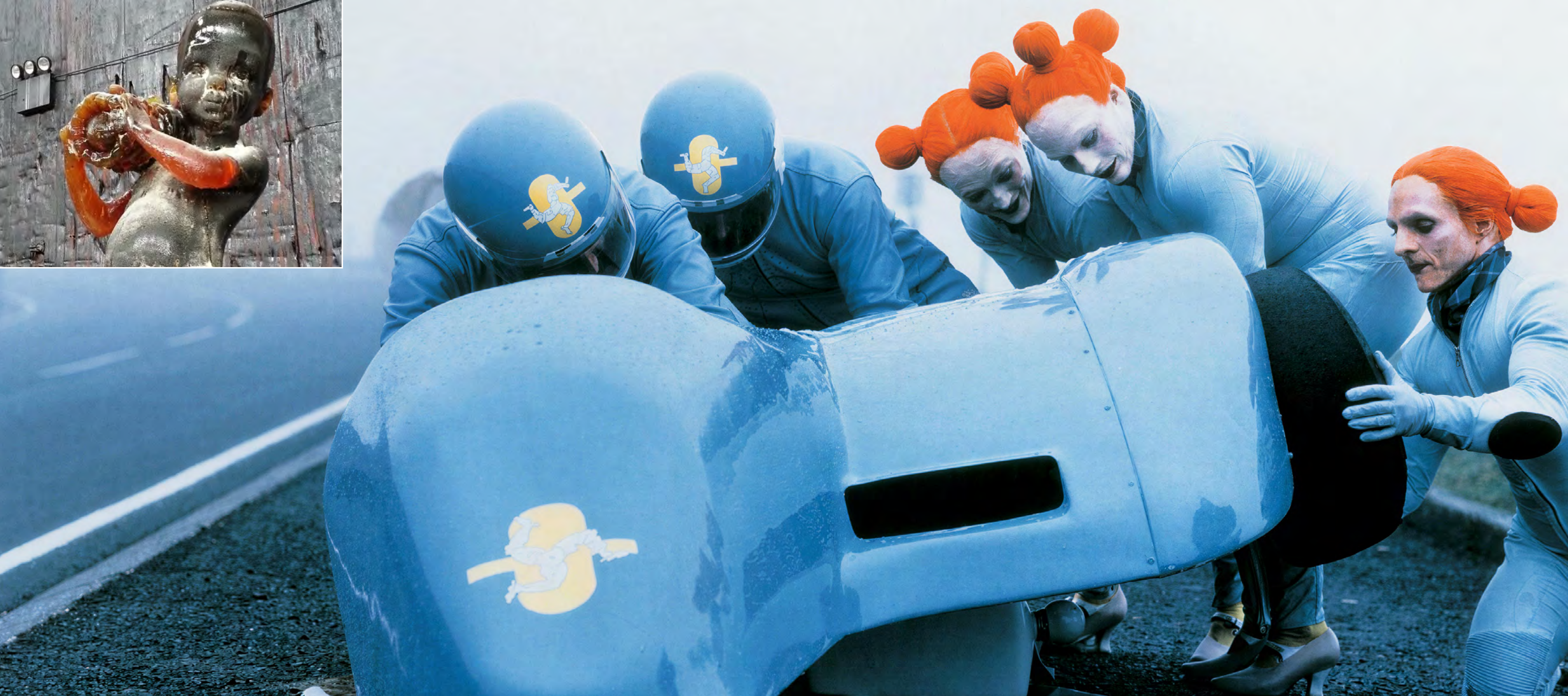
Matthew Barney was born in 1967 in San Francisco. In 1989 he graduated from Yale University. Since then, he has created work that fuses sculptural installations with performance art and video. His singular vision foregrounds the physical rigors of sport and its erotic undercurrents to explore the limits of the body and sexuality. In this way, the artist's work reflects his own past as an athlete, while also being attuned to a new politics of the body evident in the work of many contemporary artists. Barney's ritualistic actions unfold in hybridized spaces that at once evoke a training camp and medical-research laboratory, equipped as they are with wrestling mats and blocking sleds, sternal retractors and speculums, and a range of props often cast in, or coated with, viscous substances such as wax, tapioca, and petroleum jelly. Indeed, his earliest works, created at Yale, were staged at the university's athletic complex. Within this alternative universe, Barney's protagonists—including an actor dressed as Oakland Raider Jim Otto, and the artist himself naked or cross-dressed—engage in a metaphoric dance of sexual differentiation.

Barney's exploration of the body draws upon an athletic model of development, in which growth occurs only through restraint: the muscle encounters resistance, becomes engorged and is broken down, and in healing becomes stronger. This triangulated relationship between desire, discipline,

and productivity provides the basis for Barney's meditation on sexual difference. These athletic and sexual references converge in Otto's jersey number "00," which becomes a leitmotif for the artist's ongoing exploration of a polymorphous sexuality. Woven cipherlike throughout Barney's work, this motif intermittently appears as if marking elapsed time in his videos, and in altered form as a single oblong shape, resembling a football field. Barney notes, however, the oblong represents "the orifice and its closure—or the body and its self-imposed restraint." Homonymic with the word "auto," Otto also suggests autoeroticism, or a closed, self-sufficient system.

Barney began work on the CREMASTER cycle in 1994. Eschewing chronological order, he first produced CREMASTER 4 (1994), followed by CREMASTER 1 (1995), CREMASTER 5 (1997), CREMASTER 2 (1999), and CREMASTER 3 (2002). Along with each feature-length CREMASTER film, which Barney wrote and directed, and in which he often played one or more roles, the artist created related sculptures, drawings, and photographs. This epic cycle has as its conceptual departure point the male cremaster muscle, which controls testicular contractions in response to external stimuli. The project is rife with anatomical allusions to the position of the reproductive organs during the embryonic process of sexual differentia-





tion: CREMASTER 1 represents the most “ascended” (or undifferentiated) state, CREMASTER 5 the most “descended” (or differentiated). The cycle repeatedly returns to those moments during sexual development in which the outcome of the process is still unknown—in Barney’s metaphoric universe, these moments represent a condition of pure potentiality. As the cycle evolved over eight years, Barney looked beyond biology as a way to explore the creation of form, employing narrative models from other realms, such as biography, mythology, and geology.

Why might artists use existing Hollywood genres, like horror, slasher, or murder mystery, to create new narratives? What do these new narratives suggest?

*Matthew Barney
CREMASTER 5, 1997
Film / video
Production still*



Matthew Barney and Jonathan
Bepko
River of Fundament, 2014
Production still



Matthew Barney
Virgins, 2018
 Cast and machined brass, and
 cast and machined copper
 312.4 × 628.7 × 288.3 cm

Eleanor Antin

*Eleanor Antin
The Conversation (from The
Last Days of Pompeii), 2001
Chromogenic print
Dimensions variable*

*Eleanor Antin
The Triumph of Pan after Pous-
sin (from Roman Allegories),
2004
Chromogenic print
Dimensions variable*



In 1974 Antin wrote, “I consider the usual aids to self-definition—sex, age, talent, time and space—as tyrannical limitations upon my freedom of choice.” From the early 1970s through the early 1990s she challenged these limitations by creating and embodying multiple alter egos of different genders, races, professions, historical eras, and geographic locations. She presented this motley group, whom she called her “selves,” in works across mediums. The primary selves—a disenfranchised king, two frustrated ballerinas, and a helpless nurse—are the protagonists in a series of narrative videos, including *The King* (1972), *The Ballerina and the Bum* (1974), *The Adventures of a Nurse* (1976), and *From the Archives of Modern Art* (1987). In transforming herself into one character after another, she performed the proposition that gender, class, and racial identity are fluid. If such categories are unstable, the works suggest, then so too must be the social hierarchies that are built upon them. This position, shared by many feminist artists of Antin’s generation, was foundational for politically engaged art of the 1980s and 1990s and continues to reverberate in art today.

Since the early 2000s Antin has been making large-scale photographic tableaux that mine classical history and art history to reflect on current issues such as environmental destruction and modern warfare. These bodies of work, like the ones that precede them, are often marked by wit and humor, even as they engage serious, even dark, matters.

Working since the early 1960s, Eleanor Antin has created a body of work that explores history, contemporary culture, and identity from a feminist perspective. Before devoting herself to the visual arts, Antin was a poet and an actress. Drawing on this background, she has integrated language, character, costume, and voice into the mediums of painting, sculpture, and photography. Her disregard for the boundaries between art, performance, and theater opened possibilities for younger generations of artists working between the studio and the stage.

Initially developing her practice amid New York’s artistic and literary avant-garde, in 1969 Antin moved to San Diego, where she became deeply involved with the local feminist movement and participated in activities at the Woman’s Building, an arts and education center in Los Angeles. She was also a key figure within the vibrant community of leftist artists and writers affiliated with the University of California, San Diego, where she taught from 1975 until 2002.





When Conceptual art arrived, suddenly
there was a feast of possibilities....



*Eleanor Antin
Constructing Helen (from
Helen's Odyssey), 2007
Gelatin silver print
Dimensions variable*

*Eleanor Antin
Constructing Polyphemus (from
Helen's Odyssey), 2007
Gelatin silver print
Dimensions variable*



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DEPARTMENT OF HUMAN
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Eleanor Antin
100 Boots at the Bank,
1971-1973
Gelatin silver print
8 x 10 in / 20.3 x 25.4 cm



Eleanor Antin
Helen Welcomed to Hades, 2007
 Chromogenic color print
 Dimensions variable

Eleanor Antin
The Last Days of Pompeii, 2001
 Chromogenic color print
 Dimensions variable

Eleanor Antin
Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man (Antinova), 1971
 Black-and-white photograph,
 installation with 35mm film
 Dimensions variable

